



URBAN VISION
Dakshineshwar Skywalk (left); Vanijya Bhavan, Delhi (below) are examples of the range of DFI's exemplary work

FOR THE DISCERNING EYE

In 2003, the founders took a crowbar to their own front door, scraping off their individual surnames to rebrand as an egalitarian collective. "We are not creating pieces of art or status symbols; we are creating built environments meant for people to use," emphasises Sharma. This philosophy transformed how DFI approaches public spaces. For instance, they look at airports strictly through the lens of a dazed, travel-weary flyer trying to navigate their way; or they design courthouses through the eyes of a stressed, disoriented litigant seeking a moment of relief. "We used to follow facades, now we follow experience," adds Tevatia.

DEATH OF MARBLE LUXURY

This brings us to the grand architectural question of 2026: What defines luxury for the modern Indian? Sharma is quick to dismiss the lazy real estate industry defaults. "Luxury is a highly abused word. If it were merely something you could buy with money, then all the wealthy people would have automatically bought it. Luxury means no compromise." For DFI, 2026 luxury has moved from the visible to the invisible. It is no longer about slapping premium Italian marble onto a concrete wall. It is about satisfying the unique behavioural shifts of the modern Indian family. Luxury is now measured in dedicated, hyper-specific spatial nooks, an informal breakfast corner for a couple, a quiet study zone for children and a perfectly private outdoor deck for an evening drink.

To prove the point, they point to a private villa they executed in Vasant Vihar, Delhi. Instead of designing a predictable, marble-clad luxury bathroom, DFI installed a massive sheet of seamless fixed glass along an entire wall. Outside the glass sits a private, one-metre-deep landscaped pocket of soaring palm trees concealed behind elegant privacy louvres. The washbasin is a dramatic free-standing cylindrical sculpture with a sleek spout dropping water directly from the ceiling. By upending expectations, a utilitarian room is transformed into an uncompromised personal sanctuary.

If the trio is to be believed, a great design idea clicks in your mind within the first 15 minutes. The seed is either there or it isn't. The master stroke of a project is always captured early. Everything after that is simply putting the pieces together. Which is why the grand narrative of DFI isn't found in their staggering archive of over 2,000 completed buildings, but in operating as an architectural triumvirate where ideological tension serves as the primary engine for innovation.